

### Step 3: Choose your off-site copy

Pick the cloud service that fits your ecosystem:

- **Google One** for Android-heavy homes and Google Photos users
- **iCloud+** for iPhone, iPad and Mac households
- **OneDrive/Microsoft 365** for Windows-first users, especially if Desktop/Documents/Pictures workflows matter

The cheapest plan is not always the smartest. Choose the one your household will actually use consistently. Google One storage spans Drive, Photos, and Gmail; iCloud storage spans backups, photos, files and more; Microsoft 365 plans add OneDrive cloud storage and backup features tied to Windows workflows.

### Step 4: Turn on automatic backup where possible

On Windows, configure Windows Backup and folder protection where applicable. On iPhone, turn on iCloud Backup and decide whether iCloud Photos should be part of the strategy. On Android, turn on Google Photos backup and review device backup settings in your Google account. Automation matters because humans are forgetful, optimistic, and usually one busy week away from neglect. Microsoft and Apple both document these flows officially, and Google Photos explicitly supports automatic backup to your Google Account.



### Step 5: Make one manual local copy

Plug in the external drive and manually copy your most important folders. Do not overcomplicate this. The first goal is having another recoverable copy that is not dependent on perfect sync behaviour.

### Step 6: Disconnect the drive when done

This is the part many people skip. If the drive remains permanently attached, it is more vulnerable to power issues, user mistakes, and malware or ransomware that can reach connected storage. CISA's stress on offline backups is not paranoia; it is the difference between "copy exists" and "copy survives the same attack."

## THREE COMMON MISTAKES THAT BREAK 3-2-1

- 1) The first mistake is treating sync as your only backup. It is fantastic for continuity, but synced deletion, corruption, or account trouble can still ruin your day. Apple's documentation makes clear that iCloud Photos syncs changes across devices, while iCloud Backup handles other device data not already synced. That distinction exists for a reason.
- 2) The second mistake is keeping all copies in one place. Two drives in one bag are still one accident away from tragedy. NIST's off-site requirement remains relevant precisely because homes and devices fail in clusters.
- 3) The third mistake is never testing. People lovingly create backup systems they have never once restored from. Then comes panic, followed by discovery, followed by language not fit for publication. CISA's repeated insistence on testing exists because broken backups are incredibly common.

### Step 7: Test a restore

Open random files from the external drive. Restore one deleted document from the cloud. Confirm photos are actually accessible from another device. CISA says to regularly test backup availability and integrity. This is not optional theatre; it is how you discover broken assumptions before a real emergency.

### What 3-2-1 looks like in real life

A good backup rule should not make you feel guilty. It should make you calmer.

- 1) If you are an Android user with a Windows laptop, your setup might be: phone originals + external SSD + Google One.
- 2) If you are deep in Apple land: iPhone/Mac originals + local Time Machine or external drive + iCloud+.
- 3) If you are a Windows household: PC originals + external HDD + OneDrive or Microsoft 365.

The exact brands matter less than the structure. Three copies. Two media types. One off-site. Once you understand that pattern, every platform starts making more sense.

That is the quiet brilliance of the 3-2-1 rule. It is old enough to sound boring, but still modern enough to save you from very current disasters. And in a world where our phones increasingly hold our memory, identity, money trails, and work, boring is exactly what you want from a backup strategy. 